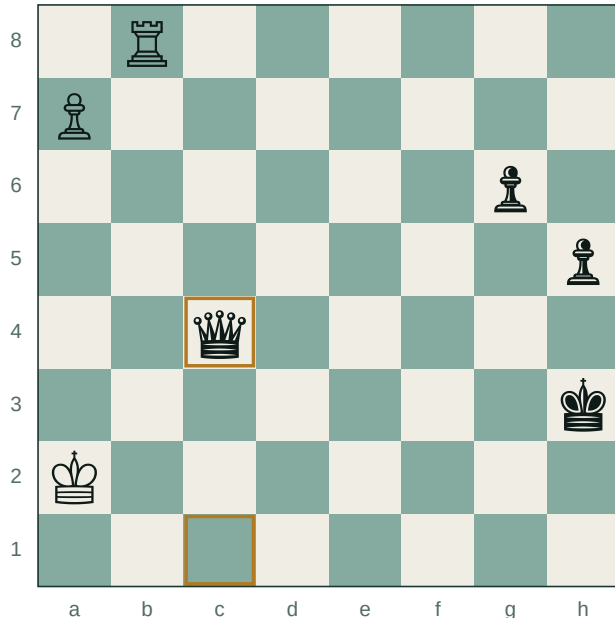


Queen-and-rook endings: White, move 44

Queen-and-rook endings

White to move



Previous move: 43...Qc4+. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

44. Rb3+ Kg4 45. a8=Q

44.Rb3+ Check restricts Black to 7 legal replies here. Recorded reply: **44...Kg4**.

45.a8=Q The pawn moves from a7 to a8. The pawn becomes a queen.

At the end, nominal material is White 14 / Black 11 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +8. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +8: the balance goes from -5 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not activate the king as casually as in a pure pawn ending. The remaining heavy pieces can still generate a mating net.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

When queens and rooks remain, mating threats coexist with endgame pawn races. Coordination and king shelter remain essential even on a sparse board.

HOW TO LOOK

Look for heavy-piece batteries, skewers, and checks that force a defender away from a promotion square or pawn.

The defending king is on h3. Geometrically undefended: queen on c4. Check for tactical protection.